

Athens-Clark County | Mayor and Commissioners | Data Centers | Moratorium

Athens-Clarke County Commission Extends Delay on Data Center Moratorium

March 4, 2026 | Reported by Grace Park



 **B-Roll Clip** Community members attend the Athens-Clarke County Mayor and Commission meeting at City Hall on March 3, 2026, in Athens, Ga. The meeting included discussion of data centers, and commissioners later voted to keep the temporary pause on new proposals in place through June 5. [Photo/Grace Park]

[The Athens-Clarke County mayor and commissioners](#) voted Tuesday at the regular session commission meeting. They decided to extend a temporary pause on new data centers through June 5, keeping new project proposals on hold after residents expressed their concerns on the increase in utility costs, strain on local water and power systems.

The vote came March 3 at City Hall during the regular voting meeting. The pause on new data centers started in December, and the March 3 vote pushed that deadline back to early June.

According to [Grady Newssource](#), concerns about power demand, water use and rising utility costs had kept data centers a recurring topic of debate in Athens.

Tawana Mattox, who holds a doctorate in higher education leadership and is an Athens resident, urged county commissioners to reject new data centers in Athens.

“No more data centers in our Black and working-class neighborhoods,” said Mattox.

Mattox said Athens-Clarke County was too small to absorb the demands of large facilities and argued that nearby residents, not companies, would bear the biggest costs through higher utility bills, increased water use, noise and environmental risks. She also said data centers created few permanent jobs and that any tax benefits often did not reach the people living closest to the sites.

“We cannot trade our health, our water, our air, our neighborhoods for corporate profit,” Mattox said.

Other residents asked the commissioners to use the extra time to demand more language that ensures community benefit when it comes to proposing data centers.

Olivia Asher, who lives at 105 College Station Road, said that county leaders should take more time before moving forward on the data center proposals so that there is stronger protection for local residents. She also said future rules should require energy-use auditing, meaning regular checks or reports that show how much electricity a data center uses and whether that demand places added pressure on the local power system. She said those reviews could be handled through the Georgia Public Service Commission or by outside experts.

Asher also urged the county to consider community benefit agreements for any proposed facility, prevent several data centers from being built in the same area and require a clear end-of-use plan for sites that are no longer operating.



Commissioners' seats sit inside the Athens-Clarke County commission chamber at City Hall on March 3, 2026, in Athens, Ga. The chamber is where commissioners vote on council topics. [Photo/Grace Park]

In an interview, [District 9 Commissioner Ovita Thornton](#) said she initially saw the data center in her district as just a warehouse, but later grew concerned about what another facility could mean for nearby residents. Thornton said neighborhoods near Pittard Road and Spring Valley Road already faced industrial pressures, and she questioned whether it was fair to place another large energy-intensive facility near low-income and predominantly Black communities.

"I think we will come up with some good ordinance that will help prevent the expansion of data centers," said Commissioner Thornton.

Commissioners approved the extension without opposition. Commissioner Ovita Thornton made the motion and Commissioner Melissa Link seconded it.